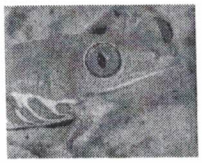
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You Can't Take Them Home at Night



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By Brian Weilert

The bell rings and the children file out the door; only half the class. The "bus kids" left five minutes ago. I say goodbye and tell them all to have a great weekend. My eyes scan the cubbies, floor, desks for abandoned coats, bags, books, glitter lip gloss, insects in mayonnaise jars with fork-poked tops. I am exhausted. No one can know the energy transferred each day in a grade school classroom. Them, tired as they shuffle in sucking energy from my coffee induced morning cheer, "How are we doing today? Isn't the sunshine wonderful? Blah Blah." By midday, it is me that must vampire energy, vacuuming as much as I can from the power created by tickle giggles, colored pictures and hugs. Back and forth all day until I sit drained, unable to move. They barely have energy left to go home and play for another four hours. Each child seems to leave a bit of themselves behind each Friday: half gnawed pencils, smells, memories. At the far left desk, front of the room, I see Jessica has papers bursting from under the hinged top as if fighting each other for air. A great wrinkled globule. I pry myself from the comfort of my chair, a soft pleather, purchased by **me** for $49.99 on sale at Sam's with my temporary card given because I am a teacher. One of those hidden perks that keep people assured that this job is too easy and we are overpaid. It had been the first time I had sat down all day. I rise and move slowly toward the white-lined blob vomiting itself from beneath the desktop. I can make out the name on one of the papers, Jessica, with the "c" backwards.

Jessica is beautiful child, dark deep chocolate marble eyes, flawless skin, the color of linseed-oiled mahogany, long black hair. Her mother told me she was Native American. I remember making a note of it on a pink post-it. All our Thanksgiving worksheets use the word *Indian,* I hoped to avoid conflict. Jessica has fallen behind, failing many tests. When I asked if there was something else wrong she shared with me not one, but both of her parents were in jail. Mom, hot checks. Dad, DUI, number three. Jessica was with grandma, again. Last year she spent time there as well. Her family was evicted. They found a rental out of our district so Jessica stayed at Grandma's. I drove her home to her parents once. She was staying after school with me for extra tutoring. She used to beg me to stay after school even when it wasn't her night.
"Can I go home with you?"
I can't do that. So many times I wanted to say, "Yes, you can come and live with me so you can become all the great things I know you have inside. So you have a chance." But I quickly come back to the reality of it all, not my child. As I pulled into the driveway of the rental house, her father waved and gave me a smile. He was finishing what was left

in his *Bush Lite* can. In front of him was a large box of scattered parts to a new gas grill. I had seen it at *Sears* earlier in the week for $259.00. Nice one, but too much money for me. I wanted to leap from my car, grab the man and scream, "WHAT THE HELL ARE YOU DOING?! YOUR CHILD'S DRESSES ARE TWO SIZES TOO SMALL! NO HOME! NO TOYS! NO LOVE! AND YOU GO AND BUY A $259.00 GRILL? WHAT PSYCHO, BIZARRE, FREAKED-OUT REALITY DO YOU LIVE IN?!" *SHAKE SHAKE SHAKE* "WELL ?!" But instead, I wave back, half smile and back down the drive. My job forces me to bite my tongue, off if need be.

A clank and a squeal-whistle from the guinea pig cage brings me back to real time. I move over and see that they have devoured the duct tape which held the water bottle in place. Now thirsty, they cry out for the mistake they made. Funny how some parents are the same way. With this thought, I look over at Max's desk; alone, in the corner. He has a special place in my heart. His mom always complaining about him, unable to understand why he is the way he is, as she screams, "What is wrong with you?! Why are you so stupid?!" Max, the metaphorical water bottle, chewed to the ground. Rags for shirts mimicking the frayed duct tape. Mildly amused by my word play, I laugh to myself as I think of her, the mother, as the guinea pig.

Max has a smile that melts you. A lisp that makes you love him. I remember last year during Thanksgiving. Max had been given a small part for the play. Mom, who has four kids with four different men never, never, never looks at his papers....until that day. That day, she looks and helps him learn his part. The following week, practice day, Max came in dressed as an Indian, Native American. I was shocked. That was not his part. When I told him, he cried, with a lisp, "I am an Indian, I know I'm an Indian!" Tears glistened on his red cheeks. I told him to go get his script from his bag. He did. At the top: **INDIAN**. I had given him the wrong paper. Teacher error. I now had too many Native Americans. In one of the many mistakes I make each year, I hastily decided to remedy the situation with a class vote. All my Native Americans left the room. When I called Max's name, no one raised their hand. When they came back in I took him aside. I should have held auditions. I didn't know what to say to him. I lied, telling him it was a very close vote. My heart ached, my stomach. At a loss, I stumbled into the forbidden. I told him, I wished I could take him home. Through moist eyes, he smiled. Instantly lighting up, "I think that would be okay. My Mom thayths I'm a bad boy anywayth." I hugged him tight, so he can't see my tears.

I pick up the guinea pig's water bottle, walk across the room to the sink, wash off the cedar shavings and fill it back up. I take a moment to pull two or three Puffs from the box and wipe my eyes. The sting from hurting Max last year renewed with the memory. As I peer down on the wad of damp tissues within my grasp, I smile. I remember Max's frustration from never being able to pull one Puff from the opening. "Thstupid Puffths, they rig the boxth you know."
"Thstupid Puffths", I say, as I toss the tissues in the trash.

One last scan of the room, a deep breath. I am thankful for Saturday. I am suddenly thankful for my family. I will call my parents when I get home. As I fish my

keys from my desk drawer, my hand contacts something foreign. I reach in and pull out a paper snowflake. Words in red crayon interrupted by rough-cut geometric shapes spread out across the flake. ***you are one of a ɔind*** "Kind" spelled with a "C"; backwards. I switch off the lights. The soft blue glow from the aquarium illuminates the room. "Goodnight my children. Stay safe. I will see you on Monday."

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